

The Vedic Age and the Second Urbanisation - The Foundation Track

Chapter F5.2 — From Zero: The Rig Vedic and Later Vedic Worlds, the Sixteen Mahajanapadas, India's Second Cities, the Rise of Magadha and the Foreign Invasions

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NOTE · HOW TO USE THIS DOCUMENT

F5.1 left the Harappan cities in ruins around 1900 BCE and the subcontinent without cities for over a thousand years. This chapter covers that gap and the moment cities return. It opens on an evidence reversal that governs everything: the Harappans left THINGS and no readable words, the Vedic people left WORDS and almost no things - so Harappan questions are about sites and objects, and Vedic questions are about texts and terms. It then teaches the Rig Vedic world (pastoral, cattle-reckoned, governed through assemblies by a chief who was neither landowner nor tax-collector), the four Vedas with the four layers inside each, the Vedangas and the six schools of philosophy, and the later Vedic transformation in which iron and the move into the Ganga-Yamuna doab convert a tribal chief into a territorial king with taxes, officials and great sacrifices. It closes on the sixth century BCE: the sixteen mahajanapadas, the SECOND urbanisation with its Northern Black Polished Ware and India's first true coinage, the rise of Magadha through four dynasties, and the Persian and Macedonian invasions. Study time 4 hours.

This is the FOUNDATION layer. Vedic dates are conventional and approximate: the internal chronology of the Vedic texts rests on linguistic layering rather than any dated document, and scholarly ranges differ. Pre-Mauryan dynastic dates are the conventional ones and are approximate. Where a figure is genuinely disputed - which sixteen appear in a given mahajanapada list, the regnal dates of the Haryanka kings, the precise year Alexander turned back - the standard convention is printed and the dispute is named rather than concealed.

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0. Why This Chapter Sits Between Two Sets of Cities

India urbanises twice. This chapter is the thousand years in between, and it ends at the moment the second wave begins.

WHY THIS EXISTS · WHAT THIS CHAPTER IS FOR

F5.1 closed at about **1900 BCE** with the Harappan cities emptying. **India then has no cities at all for roughly thirteen hundred years.** Cities return in the **sixth century BCE**, in an entirely different part of the country - the middle Ganga plain rather than the Indus - and on an entirely different basis.

That gap, and the return, is the whole of this chapter. Three things happen inside it, and each is examinable in its own way:

- 1 **A society we know only through its literature** occupies the north-west and then moves east. This is the **Vedic** period, and it supplies India's oldest surviving texts
- 2 **Iron and the plough** open the heavy, forested soils of the Ganga-Yamuna doab, producing a surplus large enough to support cities again
- 3 **Tribes become states.** Sixteen of them, the **mahajanapadas**, and one of them - **Magadha** - eventually swallows the rest, which is how the Mauryan empire of F5.4 becomes possible

Why the chapter matters for the paper beyond its own facts. The sixth century BCE is the doorway to three separate high-yield topics: **Buddhism and Jainism** (F5.3), which are reactions against the ritual religion this chapter describes; **the Mauryas** (F5.4), who inherit Magadha's machinery; and **the first Indian coinage and guilds**, which recur in economy questions. **Get this chapter right and three later ones become easier.**

PYQ CONNECTION · WHERE THE MARKS ACTUALLY ARE IN THIS CHAPTER

Applying the F5.1 method honestly, this chapter is a **mixed-yield** one, and you should know which parts to hold tightly.

- 1 **HIGH yield - the Vedic texts.** Which Veda is which, what each contains, the four layers, and the named Upanishads. **Text-identification questions are a staple of every objective paper that touches ancient India**
- 2 **HIGH yield - the distinctive-feature pairings.** Painted Grey Ware for later Vedic, Northern Black Polished Ware for the second urbanisation, iron as *krishna ayas*. These are exactly the "which is characteristic of" answers F5.1 warned you to collect
- 3 **MODERATE yield - Vedic society and assemblies.** The **Sabha, Samiti and Vidatha** set recurs, and the single most-asked fact in it is that **the Vidatha is the earliest and women took part**
- 4 **MODERATE yield - the mahajanapadas and Magadha.** Usually asked as a capital-to-kingdom pairing or a dynastic sequence
- 5 **LOWER yield but cheap - the invasions.** Alexander's date and the battle against Porus are single-fact questions that cost almost nothing to hold

Do not attempt to memorise all sixteen mahajanapadas with their capitals. The paper asks about the four that mattered and the republics. Section 3 marks which are which, and **the stopping rule from F5.1 applies here as strictly as anywhere.**

STUDY SESSION · CHAPTER F5.2 - THE FOUR SESSIONS

- 1 **Session 1 - The Vedic framework and the texts:** the evidence reversal, the two phases, the four Vedas, the four layers, the Vedangas and the six schools (Section 1)
- 2 **Session 2 - Vedic society, politics and religion:** early Vedic pastoral life and its assemblies, the Rig Vedic gods, and the later Vedic transformation (Section 2)
- 3 **Session 3 - The mahajanapadas and the second urbanisation:** sixteen states, monarchies and republics, and the return of cities, coins and guilds (Section 3)
- 4 **Session 4 - The rise of Magadha and the foreign invasions:** four dynasties, why Magadha won, and the Persians and Alexander (Section 4)

Then **42 graded questions**. Budget **four sessions**, about **a day and a half**.

1. Session 1 - The Vedic Framework and the Texts



From cities we cannot read to a society whose literature survives entire but which left almost no archaeology. The evidence flips completely.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH · THE REVERSAL TO NOTICE BEFORE ANY OF THE FACTS

Register the contrast first, because it explains why the two topics feel so different to study.

The Harappans left us THINGS and no readable words. Cities, drains, seals, weights, statues - and a script nobody can read. So everything said about their society is inference from objects, and it is thin on politics, religion and law.

The Vedic people left us WORDS and almost no things. The Rig Veda survives complete, transmitted orally with extraordinary fidelity for millennia before being written down. But they built in wood and mud, moved with their cattle, and left no cities to excavate. **So we know their gods, their assemblies, their poetry and their quarrels in detail, and we cannot point to their capital.**

Two consequences for how questions are set:

- 1 **Harappan questions are about SITES AND OBJECTS** - where, what material, what find
- 2 **Vedic questions are about TEXTS AND TERMS** - which Veda, which hymn, what a word meant, which assembly, which official

So this session is deliberately a vocabulary and text exercise, and that is not a shortcoming of the teaching - it is the shape of the evidence. Learn the terms and you have learned the period.

MUST MASTER · THE FRAMEWORK: TWO PHASES, TWO ECONOMIES

- 1 **Early Vedic (Rig Vedic): c. 1500-1000 BCE.** Source: the **Rig Veda** alone. Geography: the **Sapta Sindhava**, the land of the seven rivers - the Punjab and the north-west. **Pastoral** economy, cattle-centred
- 2 **Later Vedic: c. 1000-600 BCE.** Sources: the later three Vedas, the **Brahmanas, Aranyakas and Upanishads**. Geography: an eastward shift into the **Ganga-Yamuna doab** and on to Kosala, Kashi and Videha. **Settled agriculture with iron**

The three markers separating the phases, and every "later Vedic" question rests on one of them:

- 1 **Iron** - called **krishna ayas** or **shyama ayas**, literally "dark metal". Unknown in the Rig Veda, standard later. Iron axes cleared the doab's forest and iron shares broke its heavier soil
- 2 **Pottery** - the later Vedic period correlates archaeologically with **Painted Grey Ware (PGW)**. **This is the single most useful archaeology-to-text link in the period**
- 3 **The state** - the Rig Vedic **rajan** is a tribal chief among kinsmen; the later Vedic king is a territorial ruler legitimated by great sacrifices and served by a staff of officials

One geographical fact that repays learning. The Rig Veda's most praised river is the **Saraswati**, called **naditama**, "best of rivers"; the **Indus is Sindhu** and the **Sutlej is Shutudri**. **The Ganga is barely mentioned in the Rig Veda and becomes central afterwards** - which is the eastward shift visible inside the texts themselves.

1.1 The four Vedas

Four Vedas, and each has four layers. Get the two-dimensional structure right and a whole family of questions becomes trivial.

Veda	Character	The facts asked
Rig Veda	Hymns of praise	The oldest Veda and the oldest surviving Indian text. 10 mandalas , about 1,028 hymns . Mandalas 2 to 7 are the family books and the oldest core; 1, 8, 9 and 10 are later. Mandala 9 is devoted wholly to Soma . Mandala 10 contains the Purushasukta , the hymn that first sets out the four varnas. The Gayatri mantra , addressed to Savitri , is in Mandala 3
Sama Veda	Melodies	Rig Vedic hymns set to tune for chanting. The origin of Indian classical music - and that pairing is the standard question. Its priest is the Udgatri
Yajur Veda	Sacrificial formulae	The ritual handbook: what the priest says and does. Contains prose as well as verse, and is therefore the first Indian text with prose . Two recensions, Krishna (black) and Shukla (white) . Its priest is the Adhvaryu
Atharva Veda	Charms and spells	Magic, medicine, cures, curses and domestic ritual. The last of the four to be composed and admitted , and long not counted as a Veda at all. Also called Brahma Veda . The best source for popular belief and everyday life

The four Vedas

START FROM ZERO · THE FOUR LAYERS WITHIN EACH VEDA

Each Veda accumulated four layers, moving from ritual towards philosophy. **The progression is itself examinable, because it is the intellectual history of the period in one line.**

- 1 **Samhita** - the collection of hymns itself. The core
- 2 **Brahmana** - prose explanations of the rituals: how to perform them, and what each act means. **Ritual-technical**
- 3 **Aranyaka** - the "forest books", for study away from settlement. Transitional, moving from ritual towards its inner meaning
- 4 **Upanishad** - philosophical dialogue and speculation. **Also called Vedanta, "the end of the Veda"** - both because they come last and because they are held to be its culmination

The direction of travel matters: from ritual ACT, to ritual MEANING, to metaphysical SPECULATION. The Brahmanas ask how to perform the sacrifice correctly; the Upanishads ask whether the sacrifice matters at all. **That internal critique, arising inside the Vedic tradition itself, is the intellectual ground from which Buddhism and Jainism grow in the sixth century BCE** - which is where F5.3 picks up.

The named Brahmanas worth recognising: Aitareya and Kaushitaki (Rig), Panchavimsha or Tandyā and Jaiminiya (Sama), Taittiriya and Shatapatha (Yajur), Gopatha (Atharva). **The Shatapatha Brahmana is the largest and most important** and is the source for much of what is known about later Vedic ritual, kingship and the eastward expansion.

On the Upanishads: traditionally **108**, of which about **13 are principal**; the oldest are the **Brihadaranyaka** and the **Chandogya**. **The national motto "Satyameva Jayate" comes from the Mundaka Upanishad** - worth holding because it links this period to a Polity question.

1.2 The Vedangas and the six schools

Two short lists that appear as matching questions, and both are cheap marks.

Set	Item	What it is, or who founded it
Vedanga	Shiksha	Phonetics and pronunciation
Vedanga	Kalpa	Ritual procedure
Vedanga	Vyakarana	Grammar - Panini's Ashtadhyayi is the great work
Vedanga	Nirukta	Etymology - Yaska's Nirukta , the earliest Indian work on word derivation
Vedanga	Chhanda	Metre and prosody
Vedanga	Jyotisha	Astronomy, for fixing the ritual calendar
School	Samkhya	Founder Kapila . Dualism of purusha and prakriti; the oldest of the schools
School	Yoga	Founder Patanjali , of the Yoga Sutras
School	Nyaya	Founder Gautama (Akshapada). Logic, and the means of valid knowledge
School	Vaisheshika	Founder Kanada . Atomism - matter composed of indivisible particles
School	Mimamsa	Founder Jaimini . Interpretation of Vedic ritual injunction; the school of textual exegesis
School	Vedanta	Founder Badarayana , of the Brahma Sutra. Later developed by Shankara and Ramanuja

The six Vedangas and the six schools of philosophy

The two pairings most often tested are **Kanada with atomism** and **Kapila with Samkhya**. As a Mechanical Engineer, give Vaisheshika a moment: **Kanada's argument that matter must reduce to indivisible units, reached by pure reasoning about divisibility, is the same argument the Greek atomists made independently**, and it is the oldest strand of physical theory in the Indian tradition.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 1

- 1 State the evidence reversal between the Harappan and Vedic periods, and what it does to question-setting
- 2 Give both Vedic phases with dates, geography and economy
- 3 Name the three markers separating early from later Vedic
- 4 For each of the four Vedas: character, and the one fact most likely to be asked
- 5 Which mandalas are the Rig Veda's oldest core, and what is in Mandalas 3, 9 and 10?
- 6 Name the four layers in order, and state the direction of intellectual travel
- 7 Which is the largest Brahmana, and which Upanishad gives the national motto?
- 8 Name the six Vedangas, and the six schools with their founders

2. Session 2 - Vedic Society, Politics and Religion



A chief who was not a landowner, an assembly women could attend, and a war whose name means "search for cows". Then, in five hundred years, all three disappear.

MUST MASTER · EARLY VEDIC SOCIETY AND POLITICS

Economy - pastoral, and the vocabulary proves it:

- 1 Cattle were the measure of wealth. **The word for war, gavishti, literally means "search for cows"** - which tells you what Rig Vedic conflict was about
- 2 **Godhuma** is wheat and **yava** is barley. Agriculture existed but was secondary to herding
- 3 **Nishka, satamana** and **krishnala** are terms for gold ornaments used in exchange. **There was no coinage**
- 4 **No regular taxation** - voluntary offerings to the chief, called **bali**. **No standing army** either; the tribe fought as a body

Social organisation, smallest unit outward: kula (family) - **grama** (village) - **vis** (clan) - **jana** (tribe or people). **Gotra** originally meant a cow-pen and came to mean a lineage. **Varna existed but was fluid**; the rigid fourfold order is a later Vedic development, first stated in the Purushasukta of the tenth mandala.

Political institutions - the set asked most often:

- 1 **Rajan** - the tribal chief. **Not an absolute monarch, not a territorial ruler, and not the owner of land**
- 2 **Sabha** - assembly, apparently of elders or the more prominent
- 3 **Samiti** - a wider popular assembly, which could deliberate and which the rajan attended
- 4 **Vidatha** - the **earliest** of the Vedic assemblies, with religious as well as secular functions, and **the one in which women participated**
- 5 **Officials** - **Purohita** (chief priest and adviser), **Senani** (leader of the army), **Gramani** (head of a village), **Vrajapati** (officer over pasture land), **Spasa** (spies or messengers)

The single most tested fact here: the Vidatha is the earliest assembly and the one where women took part. The paper has used exactly this pairing.

KNOW · THE RIG VEDIC GODS, AND THE BATTLE OF TEN KINGS**Deities in order of prominence, measured by hymn count:**

- 1 **Indra** - the greatest, with about **250 hymns**. God of war and storm, bringer of rain, called **Purandara**, "breaker of forts"
- 2 **Agni** - second, with about **200 hymns**. Fire, and the intermediary who carries offerings to the gods. **Agni's importance is structural: the sacrifice works through him**
- 3 **Varuna** - upholder of **rita**, the cosmic and moral order; the nearest thing in the Rig Veda to a god of ethics
- 4 **Soma** - god of the sacred plant and its juice; **Mandala 9** is entirely his
- 5 **Surya, Savitri, Pushan, Rudra, Yama, Vishnu** - Vishnu is minor here and becomes major later
- 6 **Female deities are few and minor** - **Ushas** (dawn), **Aditi, Aranyani** (forest), **Ratri** (night)

The Battle of Ten Kings, the Dasarajna. Fought on the **Parushni**, the modern **Ravi**. **Sudas**, king of the **Bharatas**, defeated a confederacy of ten tribes. The priest **Vishvamitra** served Sudas first and was replaced by **Vasishtha**, and the rivalry of those two sages runs through the tradition afterwards.

Why the battle earns a place in a Foundation chapter. It is the earliest recorded conflict in Indian history, and the Bharata tribe's name is the root of **Bharata** as a name for the country. **So the constitutional first line from F1.2 - "India, that is Bharat, shall be a Union of States" - reaches back to the winning side of a cattle war on the Ravi.** That is a genuine connection, and the kind of link an interview rewards.

MUST MASTER · LATER VEDIC CHANGE - WHAT MOVED, AND WHY

Economy. Iron and the eastward shift into the doab turn a pastoral people into a farming one.

Agriculture becomes primary and the **Shatapatha Brahmana** describes ploughing ritual in detail. Rice - **vrihi** - becomes important, which it was not before. Craft specialisation increases, and the first traces of urban life appear at the very end of the period.

Politics - the rajan becomes a king. Three great royal sacrifices carry the change, each with a distinct function:

- 1 **Rajasuya** - the consecration sacrifice, conferring supreme power
- 2 **Ashvamedha** - the horse sacrifice: a horse is released to wander, and the territory it crosses unchallenged is claimed. **A territorial claim dressed as a ritual**
- 3 **Vajapeya** - the chariot-race sacrifice, establishing supremacy among peers

Administration. A staff appears - conventionally the **Ratnins**, the "jewels", about twelve office-holders around the king, including the Purohita, the Senani, the **Sangrihitri** (treasurer), the **Bhagadugha** (collector of the king's share) and the **Suta** (charioteer and bard). **Taxes become regular: bali, bhaga** (a share of produce, conventionally a sixth) and **shulka** (a toll or duty).

Society hardens. The four **varnas** become fixed and hereditary, with the **Purushasukta** supplying the origin story. **The Sabha narrows, the Vidatha disappears, and women lose their place in the assemblies** - their status declines from the Rig Vedic position. The **four ashramas** - brahmacharya, grihastha, vanaprastha, sannyasa - are formulated in this period; the **Chhandogya Upanishad** mentions three and the full four appear later.

Religion. **Prajapati** rises to supremacy; **Rudra and Vishnu** gain ground; **Indra and Varuna decline.** **Sacrifice becomes elaborate, expensive and priest-dominated** - and it is precisely this that the Upanishads begin to question from within, and that the sixth-century reform movements reject outright.

BEGINNER MISTAKE · THE THREE THINGS CANDIDATES GET BACKWARDS ABOUT THE VEDIC PERIOD

- 1 **Women's position went DOWN, not up.** Rig Vedic women attended the Vidatha, and some hymns are attributed to women seers. In the later Vedic period the Vidatha is gone and women are excluded. **Any option claiming later Vedic society was more open than early Vedic is false**, and this is a favourite statement-based trap
- 2 **The rigid varna order is LATER Vedic, not Rig Vedic.** Varna in the Rig Veda is fluid; the Purushasukta that fixes it sits in **Mandala 10, the latest layer**. So **"the fourfold varna system is a feature of the early Vedic period" is false**
- 3 **The Rig Vedic rajan did not own the land and did not tax.** He received **voluntary bali**. Regular taxation - bali, bhaga, shulka - is a **later Vedic** development, and it arrives with the territorial state

Why all three errors share a shape. Each comes from assuming that "ancient" means "uniformly traditional and hierarchical". **The actual pattern is that hierarchy INCREASED over time**, driven by the surplus that iron agriculture made possible: a surplus creates something worth controlling, and control creates permanent inequality. **That causal line - iron, surplus, state, hierarchy - is the single most useful idea in this chapter**, and it also explains the sixth-century reaction that F5.3 covers.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 2

- 1 What does gavishti mean, and what does it tell you about Rig Vedic conflict?
- 2 State the four social units from smallest outward
- 3 Name the three assemblies, and say which is earliest and which admitted women
- 4 Name five Rig Vedic officials with their functions
- 5 Give the two leading Rig Vedic gods with hymn counts, and say what rita is
- 6 Where was the Dasarajna fought, who won, and which two priests are involved?
- 7 Name the three great royal sacrifices and the function of each
- 8 Name the three later Vedic taxes, and the treasurer and collector
- 9 State the three things candidates get backwards, and the causal line explaining all three

3. Session 3 - The Mahajanapadas and the Second Urbanisation ★★★★★

Cities return after thirteen hundred years - in a different river basin, on iron and rice, with coins and guilds.

START FROM ZERO · JANAPADA TO MAHAJANAPADA - WHAT THE WORDS ARE DOING

Janapada breaks into **jana** (people, tribe) and **pada** (foot, place) - literally the place where a tribe sets its foot. **It means the territory a people occupies**, and the word's very structure records the moment a wandering tribe became attached to land. **Maha-janapada** is simply a great janapada.

Why the shift from tribe to territory is the whole point. In the Rig Veda a person belongs to a **jana** - a people. By the sixth century BCE a person belongs to a **janapada** - a place. **Identity moves from kinship to geography, and that is what a state is.** A chief rules kinsmen; a king rules whoever lives inside a boundary.

Two forms of state emerge, and the distinction is regularly asked:

- 1 **Monarchies** - hereditary kingship, the dominant form, and the one that wins. **Magadha, Kosala, Vatsa and Avanti** are the four that matter
- 2 **Gana-sanghas** or **sanghas** - usually translated **republics** or oligarchies, governed by an assembly of heads of leading families rather than by a single hereditary king. **Vajji (with its capital Vaishali), Malla, the Shakyas of Kapilavastu, the Koliyas and the Moriyas**

The republics matter for a reason beyond politics: both the Buddha and Mahavira came from them. The Buddha was a **Shakya** of Kapilavastu; Mahavira was connected with the **Vajji** confederacy. **The heterodox movements of F5.3 arise disproportionately from the republican, less Brahmanically orthodox east** - and that is not a coincidence, it is one of the standard explanations for why they arose where they did.

KNOW · THE SIXTEEN MAHAJANAPADAS - AND WHAT TO ACTUALLY LEARN

The list of **sixteen** comes from the Buddhist **Anguttara Nikaya**, with a comparable list in the Jain **Bhagavati Sutra**. **The two lists do not agree exactly**, which is why you will see different sixteens in different books - the number is a convention, not a census.

Do NOT memorise all sixteen with capitals. Applying the F5.1 stopping rule, learn these:

- 1 **Magadha** - capital **Rajgir** (Rajagriha, also called Girivraja), later **Pataliputra**. The eventual winner
- 2 **Kosala** - capital **Shravasti**. Magadha's main early rival; Ayodhya lay within it
- 3 **Vatsa** - capital **Kaushambi**, on the Yamuna. A major trade centre
- 4 **Avanti** - capital **Ujjain** (with Mahishmati as a southern centre). The last serious rival to Magadha
- 5 **Vajji** - capital **Vaishali**. **The most important republic**, a confederacy in which the **Lichchhavis** were the leading clan
- 6 **Anga** - capital **Champa**. Absorbed by Magadha early, and its absorption is Magadha's first expansion
- 7 **Kashi** - capital **Varanasi**. Wealthy, and swallowed by Kosala before Magadha took both
- 8 **Gandhara** - capital **Taxila**. The north-western state, which passes under Persian control

That is eight, and it covers essentially every mahajanapada question at this level. The remaining names - Kuru, Panchala, Matsya, Chedi, Surasena, Assaka, Malla, Kamboja - are worth **recognising as being on the list** so that a matching question cannot surprise you, and nothing more.

3.1 The second urbanisation - what returned, and on what basis

The Harappan cities were the first urbanisation. The cities of the sixth century BCE are the second, and the phrase "second urbanisation" is itself examinable. The two are separated by about thirteen centuries and share almost nothing.

Feature	First (Harappan)	Second (sixth century BCE)
Region	Indus system and Gujarat	Middle Ganga plain , and the doab
Metal	Bronze ; no iron	Iron - axes to clear forest, shares to break heavy soil
Staple	Wheat and barley	Rice , with transplantation raising yields sharply
Pottery marker	Red ware with black painted designs	Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW) - the diagnostic pottery of the period
Money	None - seals, weights, barter	Punch-marked coins , silver and copper, also called karshapana . India's first true coinage
Writing	Harappan script, undeciphered	Brahmi and Kharosthi - readable, which is why this period is historical
Political form	Unknown; no named ruler	Named kings and dated dynasties - mahajanapadas, then Magadha
Religion	Inferred from objects	Documented - Vedic ritual, plus Buddhism and Jainism

First and second urbanisation compared - the contrast is the question

HIGH YIELD · THE ECONOMIC VOCABULARY OF THE SECOND URBANISATION

This short list supplies a whole family of questions, and it is the point at which Indian economic history becomes documentary.

- 1 **Punch-marked coins (karshapana)** - India's earliest coins, symbols punched into silver or copper rather than a struck design. **The single most important economic fact of the period**
- 2 **Sreni** - a **guild** of craftsmen or merchants. Guilds regulated quality, price and training, and some acted as bankers
- 3 **Setthi** (Sanskrit **shreshthin**) - a rich merchant or **banker**, the financier of the period
- 4 **Gahapati (grihapati)** - the substantial householder and landowner, the taxpaying backbone of the new economy
- 5 **Nigama** - a market town or merchant corporation
- 6 **NBPW - Northern Black Polished Ware**, a fine, glossy, black-surfaced pottery. **A luxury ware, and the archaeological signature of the period**

Why this vocabulary matters beyond identification. Coins, guilds and bankers together mean **credit, contract and accumulation** - and an economy with those features can support a standing army and a salaried bureaucracy, which a cattle-reckoned pastoral economy cannot. **Magadha's victory in Session 4 is financed by exactly this transformation.** The order of causation is worth stating as one line: **iron → rice surplus → cities → coinage and guilds → a taxable base → a standing army → empire.**

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 3

- 1 Break down the word janapada, and say what the shift from jana to janapada represents
- 2 Distinguish a monarchy from a gana-sangha, and name three republics
- 3 Which text gives the list of sixteen, and why do lists differ?
- 4 Give the capitals of Magadha, Kosala, Vatsa, Avanti, Vajji, Anga, Kashi and Gandhara
- 5 Name six differences between the first and second urbanisations
- 6 What is NBPW, and what period does it mark?
- 7 Define sreni, setthi, gahapati and karshapana
- 8 State the causal chain from iron to empire in one line

4. Session 4 - The Rise of Magadha, and the Foreign Invasions ★★★★★

Sixteen states become one. Then, from the north-west, two empires arrive that had nothing to do with any of it.

MUST MASTER · THE FOUR PRE-MAURYAN DYNASTIES OF MAGADHA, IN ORDER

Learn the sequence, because chronological-order questions are built on it. Four dynasties take Magadha from one kingdom among sixteen to the base of an empire.

1. HARYANKA dynasty

- 1 **Bimbisara** (c. 544-492 BCE) - the founder of Magadha's greatness. **A contemporary of both the Buddha and Mahavira.** Expanded by **matrimonial alliance** - marriages connecting him to Kosala, Vaishali and Madra - and by **annexing Anga**. Capital **Rajgir** (Girivraja)
- 2 **Ajatashatru** (c. 492-460 BCE) - **killed his father Bimbisara** to take the throne. Fought and absorbed **Kashi and Kosala**, and reduced the **Vajji** confederacy after a long war. **Built a fort at Pataligrama**, the site that becomes Pataliputra. **The First Buddhist Council, at Rajgir, falls in his reign**
- 3 **Udayin** (c. 460-444 BCE) - **shifted the capital to Pataliputra**, at the Ganga-Son confluence. **The move is the examinable fact**

2. SHISHUNAGA dynasty

- 1 **Shishunaga** - **destroyed the power of Avanti**, removing Magadha's last serious rival
- 2 **Kalashoka** - **the Second Buddhist Council, at Vaishali, falls in his reign**

3. NANDA dynasty - conventionally described as the first **non-Kshatriya**, low-born dynasty, and remembered for wealth and a very large army

- 1 **Mahapadma Nanda** - the founder, called **Ugrasena** ("of terrible armies") and described as **ekarat**, sole sovereign, for uprooting rival Kshatriya houses
- 2 **Dhana Nanda** - the last, **the contemporary of Alexander's invasion**, and the king overthrown by **Chandragupta Maurya** with Kautilya's help

4. MAURYA dynasty - which is F5.4, and begins about **321 BCE**

The two Buddhist Council pairings are worth fixing now: First Council at Rajgir under Ajatashatru, Second Council at Vaishali under Kalashoka. F5.3 adds the Third under Ashoka and the Fourth under Kanishka, and the set of four is a standard matching question.

WHY THIS EXISTS · WHY MAGADHA WON - SIX REASONS, AND THEY ARE THE QUESTION

"Why did Magadha rise?" is asked directly, and the answer is a list. It is also a genuinely good piece of historical reasoning, so it is worth understanding rather than memorising.

- 1 **Iron.** The richest iron deposits in the region lay close by, around **Rajgir and southern Bihar**. **Iron means better weapons and better ploughs, and Magadha had it before its rivals could match it**
 - 2 **Fertile alluvium.** The middle Ganga plain gave heavy rice yields, and rice with transplantation gave a large, dependable **surplus** - which is a taxable base
 - 3 **Rivers.** The **Ganga and Son** carried trade and troops. Both Rajgir and Pataliputra are positioned on water, and **Pataliputra sits at a confluence, which makes it a natural fortress and a customs point**
 - 4 **Elephants.** Eastern India supplied **war elephants**, which the western states could not obtain in comparable numbers - a decisive battlefield asset before cavalry dominance
 - 5 **Capable and ruthless rulers.** Bimbisara, Ajatashatru and Mahapadma Nanda in sequence, each expanding by alliance, war or annexation
 - 6 **An unorthodox society.** Magadha was **outside the old Vedic heartland**, so it was less bound by Brahmanical convention about who could rule and how. **It could recruit and promote on ability, and it produced non-Kshatriya dynasties** - the Nandas openly so
- The most defensible one-sentence answer, and a good interview line: Magadha won because it held the best combination of iron, rice and rivers, and was least constrained by tradition in exploiting them.** Note the shape of that answer - **resources plus institutions**, not personality. That is the same shape as the F5.1 conclusion about Harappan decline, and it is how historical causation is normally argued.

4.1 The Persian and Macedonian invasions

The north-west is invaded twice while Magadha is consolidating in the east. **The two events are almost entirely separate from Indian dynastic history, which is exactly why they are easy questions.**

Invasion	When	What to know
Persian (Achaemenid)	From the mid-6th century BCE	Cyrus campaigned in the borderlands. Darius I annexed the Indus valley and Gandhara as a satrapy - described in his Behistun and Persepolis inscriptions as among the richest of his provinces. Xerxes used Indian troops in Greece. Lasting consequence: the Kharosthi script, derived from Aramaic, the Persian empire's administrative language
Macedonian (Alexander)	326 BCE in India	Alexander crossed the Indus and defeated Porus (Paurava) at the Battle of the Hydaspes , on the Jhelum - the famous engagement, after which Porus was reinstated as a ruler . His army then mutinied at the Beas (Hyphasis) and refused to advance further east towards the Nandas, so he turned back. He died at Babylon in 323 BCE . He never fought Magadha

The invasions of the north-west

KNOW · WHAT ALEXANDER'S INVASION ACTUALLY CHANGED, AND WHAT IT DID NOT

What it did NOT do. It did not conquer India, did not touch Magadha, and left no lasting Macedonian state in the subcontinent. **Alexander's Indian campaign lasted under two years and its direct political effect was close to nil** - a point worth making plainly, because popular accounts overstate it.

What it DID do, and these are the examinable consequences:

- 1 **It opened and documented land routes** between India and the west, and the accounts of Alexander's companions give **the first reasonably firm dates in Indian history** - which is why Indian chronology before this point is approximate and after it is not
- 2 **It broke up the small north-western states**, leaving a political vacuum that **Chandragupta Maurya filled** within about five years. **The invasion indirectly assisted the Mauryan founding**
- 3 **It left Greek settlements and satraps in the north-west**, which is the seed of the later **Indo-Greek** kingdoms - and those are the states that introduce **portrait coinage** to India, the fact you learned in F5.1
- 4 **It began sustained Indo-Greek cultural contact**, whose visible outcome is the **Gandhara school of sculpture** in F5.5

The clean way to hold the two invasions apart in the hall. Persian = administrative and lasting - a satrapy, tribute, and a script that survives for centuries. **Macedonian = military and brief** - one famous battle, a mutiny, a withdrawal, and an indirect consequence. **If a question asks which invasion left a script, the answer is Persian; if it asks about a battle on the Jhelum, the answer is Macedonian.**

ACTION · WHERE THIS LEAVES YOU, AND WHAT F5.3 DOES

You now hold the thousand years between India's two urbanisations: the Vedic texts and the society that made them, the hardening of that society as iron produced a surplus worth controlling, the sixteen states that surplus supported, the return of cities with coins and guilds, Magadha's victory, and the two invasions of the north-west.

One thread is deliberately left hanging. Session 2 ended with sacrifice becoming **elaborate, expensive and priest-dominated**, and with the Upanishads beginning to question it from inside the tradition. Session 3 added a second pressure: **a new commercial class of setthis and gahapatis with wealth but no rank in a birth-fixed varna order**, concentrated in the eastern republics.

F5.3 is what happens when those two pressures meet - the sixth-century BCE reform movements. **Buddhism and Jainism**, their founders, doctrines, councils, sects and vocabulary, plus the other heterodox schools. It is one of the highest-yield chapters in Module 5, because the 2023 paper's history questions clustered in exactly this territory, and because its art and architecture - stupas, chaityas, viharas - feed directly into F5.5.

5. Graded Practice - 42 Questions ★★★★★

5.1 Level 1 - Recognition

Q. 1. The oldest of the four Vedas, and the oldest surviving Indian text, is the

(a) Yajur Veda (b) Sama Veda (c) Rig Veda (d) Atharva Veda

Q. 2. The number of mandalas in the Rig Veda is

(a) 8 (b) 10 (c) 12 (d) 18

Q. 3. The Veda regarded as the origin of Indian classical music is the

(a) Rig Veda (b) Yajur Veda (c) Atharva Veda (d) Sama Veda

Q. 4. The first Indian text to contain prose as well as verse is the

(a) Yajur Veda (b) Sama Veda (c) Rig Veda (d) Atharva Veda

Q. 5. The Veda that was the last to be admitted, and is also called the Brahma Veda, is the

(a) Rig Veda (b) Atharva Veda (c) Yajur Veda (d) Sama Veda

Q. 6. The Purushasukta, the hymn setting out the four varnas, occurs in

(a) Mandala 1 (b) Mandala 3 (c) Mandala 10 (d) Mandala 9

Q. 7. The mandala of the Rig Veda devoted wholly to Soma is

(a) Mandala 3 (b) Mandala 7 (c) Mandala 10 (d) Mandala 9

Q. 8. The largest and most important of the Brahmanas is the

(a) Shatapatha (b) Aitareya (c) Gopatha (d) Jaiminiya

Q. 9. The national motto "Satyameva Jayate" is taken from the

(a) Rig Veda (b) Mundaka Upanishad (c) Chandogya Upanishad (d) Shatapatha Brahmana

Q. 10. In later Vedic literature, krishna ayas refers to

(a) copper (b) bronze (c) iron (d) gold

Q. 11. The pottery type archaeologically associated with the later Vedic period is

(a) Black-and-Red Ware (b) Ochre Coloured Pottery (c) Northern Black Polished Ware (d) Painted Grey Ware

Q. 12. The earliest of the Vedic assemblies, and the one in which women participated, was the

(a) Vidatha (b) Samiti (c) Sabha (d) Parishad

Q. 13. The Rig Vedic word gavishti, used for war, literally means

(a) search for gold (b) search for cows (c) search for land (d) search for water

Q. 14. The capital of the Vajji confederacy was

(a) Rajgir (b) Shravasti (c) Vaishali (d) Kaushambi

Q. 15. The capital of Avanti was

(a) Varanasi (b) Champa (c) Taxila (d) Ujjain

Q. 16. Alexander invaded India in

(a) 326 BCE (b) 321 BCE (c) 305 BCE (d) 261 BCE

5.2 Level 2 - Understanding**Q. 17. The school of philosophy founded by Kanada, and its central doctrine, are**

(a) Vaisheshika, atomism (b) Samkhya, dualism (c) Nyaya, logic (d) Mimamsa, ritual exegesis

Q. 18. The Vedanga dealing with etymology, and its earliest author, are

(a) Vyakarana, Panini (b) Nirukta, Yaska (c) Chhanda, Kapila (d) Jyotisha, Badarayana

Q. 19. Regular taxation in the forms of bali, bhaga and shulka is a feature of

(a) the Harappan civilisation (b) the early Vedic period (c) the later Vedic period (d) the Mauryan period alone

Q. 20. The Ashvamedha sacrifice functioned as

(a) a consecration conferring supreme power (b) an annual harvest rite (c) a chariot race establishing supremacy among peers (d) a territorial claim, since the land the released horse crossed unchallenged was claimed

Q. 21. The Ratnins of the later Vedic period were

(a) about twelve office-holders around the king, including the treasurer and the collector of the king's share (b) the twelve months of the ritual calendar (c) royal jewels used in coronation (d) a class of merchants

Q. 22. In the later Vedic period, bhaga referred to

(a) a toll or customs duty (b) a share of produce taken by the king, conventionally a sixth (c) a voluntary offering (d) a fine imposed by the assembly

Q. 23. The Battle of Ten Kings, the Dasarajna, was fought on the

(a) Sindhu (b) Saraswati (c) Parushni, the modern Ravi (d) Ganga

Q. 24. The Rig Vedic deity with the largest number of hymns, and his epithet, are

(a) Agni, the intermediary (b) Varuna, upholder of rita (c) Soma, lord of plants (d) Indra, Purandara

Q. 25. Which one of the following is correct about the Rig Vedic rajan?

(a) he was a tribal chief who received voluntary bali rather than regular taxes, and was not a territorial ruler (b) he owned all the land in the tribe's territory (c) he maintained a large standing army (d) he was elected by the Vidatha for a fixed term

Q. 26. Compared with the Rig Vedic position, the status of women in the later Vedic period

(a) improved, with wider participation in assemblies (b) declined, with exclusion from the assemblies and the disappearance of the Vidatha (c) remained unchanged (d) is not documented at all

Q. 27. The list of sixteen mahajanapadas is given in the

(a) Rig Veda (b) Arthashastra (c) Buddhist Anguttara Nikaya (d) Rajatarangini

Q. 28. The Magadhan ruler who shifted the capital to Pataliputra was

(a) Bimbisara (b) Ajatashatru (c) Mahapadma Nanda (d) Udayin

Q. 29. India's earliest coins, of silver and copper with symbols punched into the metal, are called

(a) punch-marked coins or karshapana (b) satamana (c) nishka (d) dinara

Q. 30. The Kharosthi script, used in the north-west, was derived from

(a) Brahmi (b) Aramaic, the administrative language of the Persian empire (c) Greek (d) the Harappan script

5.3 Level 3 - Recruitment Test standard

Q. 31. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Veda)	List-II (Character)
A. Rig Veda	1. Charms, spells and magic; last to be admitted
B. Sama Veda	2. Sacrificial formulae, in prose as well as verse
C. Yajur Veda	3. Hymns of praise in ten mandalas
D. Atharva Veda	4. Melodies for chanting; origin of Indian classical music

(a) A-1 B-4 C-2 D-3 (b) A-3 B-2 C-4 D-1 (c) A-3 B-4 C-2 D-1 (d) A-4 B-3 C-2 D-1

Q. 32. Which one of the following statements about the early Vedic period is NOT correct?

(a) Cattle were the chief measure of wealth (b) The rajan received voluntary bali rather than regular taxes (c) Women participated in the Vidatha (d) The fourfold varna order was already rigid and hereditary

Q. 33. Arrange the following dynasties of Magadha in correct chronological order, earliest first: 1. Nanda · 2. Haryanka · 3. Maurya · 4. Shishunaga

(a) 2-4-1-3 (b) 2-1-4-3 (c) 4-2-1-3 (d) 1-2-4-3

Q. 34. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Mahajanapada)	List-II (Capital)
A. Kosala	1. Kaushambi
B. Vatsa	2. Taxila
C. Avanti	3. Shravasti
D. Gandhara	4. Ujjain

(a) A-1 B-3 C-4 D-2 (b) A-3 B-1 C-4 D-2 (c) A-3 B-4 C-1 D-2 (d) A-2 B-1 C-4 D-3

Q. 35. Consider the following statements about the Vidatha: 1. It was the earliest of the Vedic assemblies. · 2. Women participated in it. · 3. It grew in importance during the later Vedic period. Which are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 and 3 only (c) 1 and 2 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

Q. 36. Which one of the following statements about the second urbanisation is NOT correct?

(a) Northern Black Polished Ware is its diagnostic pottery (b) Punch-marked coins appear, constituting India's first true coinage (c) Iron tools allowed forest clearance and the cultivation of heavier soils (d) It was centred on the Indus valley and Gujarat

Q. 37. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (School)	List-II (Founder)
A. Nyaya	1. Kapila
B. Vaisheshika	2. Jaimini
C. Samkhya	3. Gautama
D. Mimamsa	4. Kanada

(a) A-3 B-4 C-1 D-2 (b) A-4 B-3 C-1 D-2 (c) A-3 B-4 C-2 D-1 (d) A-1 B-4 C-3 D-2

Q. 38. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Ruler)	List-II (Associated with)
A. Bimbisara	1. Shifted the capital to Pataliputra
B. Ajatashatru	2. Annexed Anga; expanded by matrimonial alliances
C. Udayin	3. Called Ugrasena; uprooted rival Kshatriya houses
D. Mahapadma Nanda	4. Killed his father; built the fort at Pataligrama

(a) A-2 B-1 C-4 D-3 (b) A-2 B-4 C-1 D-3 (c) A-4 B-2 C-1 D-3 (d) A-3 B-4 C-1 D-2

Q. 39. The rise of Magadha is best explained by

(a) maritime trade and a large navy (b) military support from the Persian empire (c) nearby iron deposits, fertile rice-growing alluvium, position on the Ganga and Son, war elephants, capable rulers, and a society less bound by Brahmanical convention (d) its status as the oldest of the Vedic kingdoms

Q. 40. Which one of the following statements about Alexander's invasion is NOT correct?

(a) He defeated Porus at the Battle of the Hydaspes on the Jhelum (b) His army mutinied at the Beas and he turned back (c) He died at Babylon in 323 BCE (d) He defeated the Nanda ruler of Magadha

Q. 41. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Layer)	List-II (Description)
A. Samhita	1. The forest books, transitional between ritual and its meaning
B. Brahmana	2. The collection of hymns itself
C. Aranyaka	3. Philosophical speculation, also called Vedanta
D. Upanishad	4. Prose explanation of how rituals are performed and what they mean

(a) A-2 B-4 C-1 D-3 (b) A-2 B-1 C-4 D-3 (c) A-4 B-2 C-1 D-3 (d) A-1 B-4 C-2 D-3

Q. 42. Consider the following statements: 1. Iron in the later Vedic period allowed the clearing of the Ganga-Yamuna doab and produced a farming surplus. · 2. Regular taxation in the forms of bali, bhaga and shulka appears in the later Vedic period. · 3. The rigid hereditary varna order was already established in the early Vedic period. Which are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 1 and 2 only (c) 2 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

6. Answers and Explanations

6.1 Level 1 - answers

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
1	c	Rig Veda. (d) Atharva Veda is the last of the four to be composed and admitted - the opposite end of the sequence, and the intended distractor
2	b	Ten mandalas, about 1,028 hymns
3	d	Sama Veda - Rig Vedic hymns set to melody, and the root of Indian classical music. Its priest is the Udgatri
4	a	Yajur Veda - the ritual handbook, and the first Indian text containing prose. Its priest is the Adhvaryu
5	b	Atharva Veda , also called Brahma Veda , long not counted as a Veda at all. It is the best source for popular belief and everyday life
6	c	Mandala 10 - the latest layer of the Rig Veda, which is itself the point: the fourfold varna order is a LATE formulation, not an original one. (b) Mandala 3 carries the Gayatri mantra; (d) Mandala 9 is Soma's
7	d	Mandala 9 , devoted wholly to Soma , god of the sacred plant and its juice
8	a	Shatapatha Brahmana , attached to the Yajur Veda - the source for much of what is known of later Vedic ritual, kingship and the eastward expansion. (b) Aitareya belongs to the Rig Veda, (c) Gopatha to the Atharva, (d) Jaiminiya to the Sama
9	b	Mundaka Upanishad - worth holding because it connects this chapter to a Polity question about the State Emblem
10	c	Iron , literally "dark metal". Its arrival, with Painted Grey Ware and the move into the doab, is what separates later Vedic from early
11	d	Painted Grey Ware. (a) Black-and-Red Ware belongs to the Chalcolithic cultures; (c) Northern Black Polished Ware is later still and marks the second urbanisation , so it is the trap option here
12	a	Vidatha - earliest, with religious as well as secular functions, and the assembly in which women took part. (c) Sabha was of elders, (b) Samiti the wider popular assembly
13	b	"Search for cows" - the etymology proves the pastoral, cattle-reckoned character of Rig Vedic society and tells you what its wars were fought over
14	c	Vaishali , capital of the Vajji confederacy, in which the Lichchhavis were the leading clan. (a) Rajgir is Magadha, (b) Shravasti Kosala, (d) Kaushambi Vatsa
15	d	Ujjain (with Mahishmati as a southern centre). Avanti was the last serious rival to Magadha, destroyed by Shishunaga
16	a	326 BCE. (b) 321 BCE is the conventional date for Chandragupta Maurya's accession, and it is the intended near-miss

6.2 Level 2 - answers

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
17	a	Vaisheshika, founded by Kanada, whose doctrine is atomism - matter reduces to indivisible particles, argued from the impossibility of infinite division. (b) Samkhya is Kapila's, (c) Nyaya Gautama's, (d) Mimamsa Jaimini's - all three are real pairings, which is what makes the question work
18	b	Nirukta, by Yaska - the earliest Indian work on word derivation. (a) Vyakarana is grammar and Panini's Ashtadhyayi is its great work, so (a) is a true pairing but answers the wrong question

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
19	c	The later Vedic period. In the early Vedic period there was no regular taxation at all - only voluntary bali . (a) the Harappans left no evidence of taxation; (d) is wrong because these terms are attested well before the Mauryas
20	d	A territorial claim dressed as a ritual. (a) describes the Rajasuya , the consecration sacrifice; (c) describes the Vajapeya , the chariot race. All three are real sacrifices, so the question is decided by function, not name
21	a	About twelve office-holders around the king - the "jewels" - including the Sangrihitri (treasurer) and the Bhagadugha (collector of the king's share). Their appearance is the arrival of administration
22	b	A share of produce, conventionally a sixth. (a) describes shulka , a toll or duty; (c) describes bali in its early Vedic voluntary sense. Three terms, three meanings, and the paper tests exactly this separation
23	c	The Parushni, the modern Ravi. Sudas of the Bharatas defeated a confederacy of ten tribes; Vishvamitra then Vasishtha served as his priests
24	d	Indra, about 250 hymns, called Purandara, "breaker of forts". (a) Agni is second with about 200 hymns, so (a) is a true statement about the wrong deity - the classic near-miss construction
25	a	A tribal chief on voluntary bali, not a territorial ruler. (b) is false: he did not own the land. (c) is false: there was no standing army, the tribe fought as a body. (d) invents an electoral mechanism the texts do not describe
26	b	Declined. The Vidatha disappears , the Sabha narrows, and women are excluded. (a) inverts the trend and is the commonest error in this topic - later Vedic society hardened, it did not liberalise
27	c	The Buddhist Anguttara Nikaya , with a comparable list in the Jain Bhagavati Sutra . The two lists do not agree exactly, which is why different books give different sixteens - the number is a convention rather than a census
28	d	Udayin. (a) Bimbisara ruled from Rajgir ; (b) Ajatashatru only built the fort at Pataligrama on the site - he did not move the capital, and that distinction is the whole question
29	a	Punch-marked coins , also called karshapana - symbols punched into silver or copper rather than a struck design. (c) nishka and (b) satamana are Vedic gold ornaments used in exchange, not coins ; (d) dinara is a much later Gupta gold coin
30	b	Aramaic , the administrative language of the Achaemenid empire - which is why Kharosthi runs right to left while Brahmi runs left to right. This is the lasting consequence of the Persian invasion , and it is the cleanest way to distinguish the Persian from the Macedonian contact

6.3 Level 3 - answers

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
31	c	A-3 Rig hymns in ten mandalas · B-4 Sama melodies · C-2 Yajur sacrificial formulae with prose · D-1 Atharva charms and spells, last admitted. Option (b) swaps Sama and Yajur, which is the intended trap - and knowing only that Sama means music eliminates it
32	d	(d) is the false statement. Varna in the early Vedic period was fluid ; the rigid hereditary order is a later Vedic development resting on the Purushasukta of Mandala 10 . (a), (b) and (c) are all true of the early Vedic period
33	a	2-4-1-3: Haryanka, then Shishunaga, then Nanda, then Maurya. Haryanka gives Bimbisara, Ajatashatru and Udayin; Shishunaga destroys Avanti; the Nandas end with Dhana Nanda, Alexander's contemporary; the Mauryas begin about 321 BCE. This sequence is the spine of Session 4 and is asked directly

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
34	b	A-3 Kosala-Shravasti · B-1 Vatsa-Kaushambi · C-4 Avanti-Ujjain · D-2 Gandhara-Taxila. Knowing only Gandhara-Taxila and Avanti-Ujjain eliminates (a), (c) and (d) - the F5.1 partial-knowledge method again
35	c	1 and 2 only. The Vidatha is the earliest Vedic assembly and women took part. Statement 3 is false and reverses the actual trend: in the later Vedic period the Vidatha disappears, the Sabha narrows, and women are excluded
36	d	(d) is false. The second urbanisation was centred on the middle Ganga plain and the doab , not the Indus valley and Gujarat - that describes the FIRST urbanisation , which is exactly the confusion the option is built to exploit. (a), (b) and (c) are all correct
37	a	A-3 Nyaya-Gautama · B-4 Vaisheshika-Kanada · C-1 Samkhya-Kapila · D-2 Mimamsa-Jaimini. Kanada with atomism and Kapila with Samkhya carry most of these questions , and fixing those two alone eliminates (b) and (d)
38	b	A-2 Bimbisara annexed Anga and married into Kosala, Vaishali and Madra · B-4 Ajatashatru killed his father and built the fort at Pataligrama · C-1 Udayin shifted the capital to Pataliputra · D-3 Mahapadma Nanda, called Ugrasena. Option (a) swaps Ajatashatru and Udayin on the Pataliputra point - the single most common error in Magadhan history
39	c	Resources plus institutions: iron, rice alluvium, river position, elephants, able rulers, and freedom from Brahmanical constraint on who could rule. (a) is false - Magadha was an inland power. (b) invents Persian involvement. (d) is false: Magadha lay outside the old Vedic heartland, and that unorthodoxy was an advantage rather than a pedigree
40	d	(d) is false. Alexander never fought Magadha. His army mutinied at the Beas and refused to advance east towards the Nandas, so he turned back. (a), (b) and (c) are all true. The Nandas were ended by Chandragupta Maurya, not by Alexander - and conflating the two is the error this option exists to catch
41	a	A-2 Samhita, the collection of hymns · B-4 Brahmana, prose explanation of ritual · C-1 Aranyaka, the forest books · D-3 Upanishad, philosophical speculation, also called Vedanta. The order encodes the intellectual movement from ritual ACT to ritual MEANING to metaphysical SPECULATION
42	b	1 and 2 only. Iron opened the doab and produced a surplus, and regular taxation appears in the later Vedic period. Statement 3 is false: the rigid hereditary varna order is later Vedic, resting on the Purushasukta of the Rig Veda's latest mandala. The general pattern is that hierarchy INCREASED over time, driven by the surplus - the causal line from Session 2

7. One-Minute Revision

ONE-MINUTE REVISION · CHAPTER F5.2 - THE VEDIC AGE AND THE SECOND URBANISATION

THE EVIDENCE REVERSAL Harappans left **THINGS** and **no readable words**; Vedic people left **WORDS** and **almost no things** · so **Harappan questions = sites and objects, Vedic questions = texts and terms**

FRAMEWORK Early / **Rig Vedic 1500-1000 BCE**, **Sapta Sindhava** (Punjab and north-west), **pastoral** · **Later Vedic 1000-600 BCE**, **Ganga-Yamuna doab** then Kosala, Kashi, Videha, **settled agriculture** · three separators **iron (krishna ayas / shyama ayas)**, **Painted Grey Ware**, the **territorial state** · Rig Vedic favourite river **Saraswati = naditama**; Sindhu = Indus; Shutudri = Sutlej; **Ganga barely mentioned**

THE FOUR VEDAS **RIG** hymns, oldest Indian text, **10 mandalas**, **~1,028 hymns**, **oldest core mandalas 2-7** (family books), **M9 = Soma**, **M10 = Purushasukta (varnas)**, **M3 = Gayatri to Savitri** · **SAMA** melodies, **origin of Indian classical music**, priest **Udgatri** · **YAJUR** sacrificial formulae, **FIRST Indian text with prose**, **Krishna and Shukla** recensions, priest **Adhvaryu** · **ATHARVA** charms, magic, medicine, **LAST admitted**, also **Brahma Veda**, best source for popular belief

THE FOUR LAYERS **Samhita** → **Brahmana** → **Aranyaka** → **Upanishad** = hymns → ritual explanation → forest books → metaphysics · **Upanishads = Vedanta**, **"end of the Veda"** ·

SHATAPATHA the largest **Brahmana** · Aitareya and Kaushitaki (Rig), Panchavimsha and Jaiminiya (Sama), Taittiriya and Shatapatha (Yajur), Gopatha (Atharva) · **108 Upanishads traditionally**, **~13 principal**, **oldest Brihadaranyaka and Chandogya** · **"Satyameva Jayate" = MUNDAKA UPANISHAD**

VEDANGAS Shiksha phonetics · Kalpa ritual · **Vyakarana grammar** - **PANINI's Ashtadhyayi** · **Nirukta etymology** - **YASKA** · Chhanda metre · Jyotisha astronomy

SIX SCHOOLS **Samkhya-KAPILA** (dualism) · **Yoga-PATANJALI** · **Nyaya-GAUTAMA** (logic) ·

Vaisheshika-KANADA (ATOMISM) · **Mimamsa-JAIMINI** (exegesis) · **Vedanta-BADARAYANA** (Brahma Sutra)

EARLY VEDIC SOCIETY **gavishti = "search for cows" = WAR** · godhuma wheat, yava barley · **no coinage** - nishka, satamana, krishnala are ornaments · **NO regular tax, only voluntary BALI**; **no standing army** · units **kula** → **grama** → **vis** → **jana** · **varna FLUID** · **rajan = tribal chief, NOT a landowner, NOT territorial** · assemblies **Sabha** (elders), **Samiti** (popular), **VIDATHA - EARLIEST, WOMEN PARTICIPATED** · officials **Purohita**, **Senani**, **Gramani**, **Vrajapati**, **Spasa**

RIG VEDIC GODS **INDRA ~250 hymns**, **Purandara "breaker of forts"** · **AGNI ~200 hymns**, the intermediary through whom sacrifice works · **VARUNA upholds RITA** (cosmic and moral order) ·

SOMA = Mandala 9 · Vishnu MINOR here · female deities few - Ushas, Aditi, Aranyani, Ratri ·

DASARAJNA, Battle of Ten Kings, on the PARUSHNI (Ravi): SUDAS of the **BHARATAS** wins; priests **Vishvamitra** then **Vasishtha** · **Bharata the tribe** → **Bharat the country**

LATER VEDIC CHANGE iron plus the eastward move make **agriculture primary; vrihi (rice)**

matters; **Shatapatha** describes ploughing ritual · three royal sacrifices **RAJASUYA** consecration,

ASHVAMEDHA territorial claim as ritual, **VAJAPEYA** supremacy among peers · **RATNINS ~12**

officers, **Sangrihitri** treasurer, **Bhagadugha** collector, Suta charioteer-bard · taxes **BALI, BHAGA**

(a sixth), **SHULKA** (toll) · **varna HARDENS on the Purushasukta; VIDATHA DISAPPEARS,**

women EXCLUDED · **four ashramas** formulated (Chhandogya has three) · **Prajapati supreme,**

Rudra and Vishnu rise, Indra and Varuna decline · sacrifice becomes **costly and**

priest-dominated, and the Upanishads question it from inside

THREE THINGS CANDIDATES GET BACKWARDS women's status went **DOWN** not up · rigid varna is **LATER Vedic** not early · the Rig Vedic **rajan neither owned land nor taxed** · all three share one

cause: **hierarchy INCREASED over time because the surplus created something worth**

controlling - iron → surplus → state → hierarchy

JANAPADA TO MAHAJANAPADA jana (people) + pada (place) - identity moves from kinship to geography, which is what a state is · **MONARCHIES** the winning form - **Magadha, Kosala, Vatsa, Avanti** · **GANA-SANGHAS** / republics - **Vajji (Vaishali, Lichchhavi clan leading), Malla, Shakyas of Kapilavastu, Koliya, Moriya** · the Buddha was a Shakyas and Mahavira connected with the Vajji - the heterodox movements arise from the republican, less orthodox **EAST**

THE SIXTEEN listed in the Buddhist **ANGUTTARA NIKAYA**, with a comparable Jain list in the **BHAGAVATI SUTRA**; the lists differ, so the number is a convention · capitals to know: **Magadha-Rajgir then Pataliputra · Kosala-Shravasti · Vatsa-Kaushambi · Avanti-Ujjain · Vajji-Vaishali · Anga-Champa · Kashi-Varanasi · Gandhara-Taxila** · recognise but do not memorise Kuru, Panchala, Matsya, Chedi, Surasena, Assaka, Malla, Kamboja

SECOND URBANISATION vs FIRST region **middle Ganga plain** not Indus · metal **IRON** not bronze · staple **RICE** not wheat and barley · pottery **NBPW** not red-and-black-painted · money

PUNCH-MARKED COINS (karshapana), India's first true coinage, where the Harappans had none · script **Brahmi and Kharosthi, READABLE**, so this period is historical · **named kings and dated dynasties** · **Buddhism and Jainism** documented

ECONOMIC VOCABULARY sreni = guild · setthi / shreshthin = rich merchant-banker · gahapati / grihapati = substantial householder-landowner, the taxpayer · nigama = market town or merchant corporation · **NBPW** = fine glossy luxury ware, the period's signature · **the chain: iron → rice surplus → cities → coinage and guilds → a taxable base → a standing army → empire**

MAGADHA - FOUR DYNASTIES IN ORDER HARYANKA: Bimbisara (contemporary of Buddha AND Mahavira, matrimonial alliances, annexed **Anga**, capital **Rajgir**) → **Ajatashatru (killed his father, took Kashi and Kosala, reduced Vajji, built the fort at Pataligrama, FIRST Buddhist Council at Rajgir)** → **Udayin (SHIFTED THE CAPITAL TO PATALIPUTRA)** · **SHISHUNAGA: Shishunaga destroyed Avanti; Kalashoka - SECOND Buddhist Council at Vaishali** · **NANDA: Mahapadma Nanda = Ugrasena, ekarat, uprooted rival Kshatriyas; Dhana Nanda = Alexander's contemporary, overthrown by Chandragupta Maurya** · **MAURYA from c. 321 BCE**

WHY MAGADHA WON - SIX REASONS iron deposits near Rajgir and south Bihar · **fertile rice alluvium** giving a taxable surplus · **Ganga and Son** for trade and troops, **Pataliputra at a confluence** · **war elephants** from the east · **capable and ruthless rulers** in sequence · **an unorthodox society outside the Vedic heartland**, able to promote on ability and to throw up non-Kshatriya dynasties · one-line answer: **the best combination of iron, rice and rivers, least constrained by tradition in using them - resources PLUS institutions**

THE TWO INVASIONS PERSIAN = administrative and lasting: Cyrus in the borderlands, **Darius I** made the **Indus valley and Gandhara a satrapy (Behistun inscription)**, Xerxes used Indian troops in Greece, and it left the **KHAROSTHI script, derived from ARAMAIC** · **MACEDONIAN = military and brief: Alexander, 326 BCE, beat PORUS at the HYDASPES (Jhelum) and reinstated him, army MUTINIED AT THE BEAS, turned back, died at Babylon 323 BCE, NEVER fought Magadha** · indirect effects: firmer dates for Indian chronology, a north-western vacuum **Chandragupta filled**, Greek settlements seeding the **Indo-Greeks** and their **portrait coinage**, and eventually **Gandhara sculpture**

8. Five-Minute Wall Sheet

FIVE-MINUTE WALL SHEET · CHAPTER F5.2 - VEDIC AGE AND SECOND URBANISATION

Harappans = things, no words · Vedic = words, no things

Rig Vedic 1500-1000 (Sapta Sindhava, PASTORAL) · Later Vedic 1000-600 (doab, IRON, PGW, AGRICULTURE)

Separators: IRON (krishna ayas) · PAINTED GREY WARE · the territorial STATE

Saraswati = naditama · Ganga barely in the Rig Veda

RIG: 10 mandalas, ~1,028 hymns · CORE 2-7 · M9 SOMA · M10 PURUSHASUKTA · M3 GAYATRI

SAMA = MUSIC (Udgatri) · YAJUR = FIRST PROSE (Adhvaryu) · ATHARVA = CHARMS, LAST, Brahma Veda

Samhita → Brahmana → Aranyaka → Upanishad (= VEDANTA) · SHATAPATHA largest Brahmana

"Satyameva Jayate" = MUNDAKA UPANISHAD · oldest Upanishads Brihadaranyaka + Chandogya

Vedangas: Vyakarana-PANINI · Nirukta-YASKA · + Shiksha, Kalpa, Chhanda, Jyotisha Kapila-SAMKHYA · Patanjali-YOGA · Gautama-NYAYA · KANADA-VAISHESHIKA-ATOMISM · Jaimini-MIMAMSA · Badarayana-VEDANTA

gavishti = "search for cows" = WAR · BALI voluntary, NO regular tax, NO standing army kula → grama → vis → jana · rajan NOT a landowner · varna FLUID in the Rig Veda

VIDATHA = EARLIEST ASSEMBLY, WOMEN PARTICIPATED · Sabha = elders · Samiti = popular

Officials: Purohita, Senani, Gramani, Vrajapati, Spasa

INDRA ~250 (Purandara) · AGNI ~200 · VARUNA upholds RITA · Vishnu minor

DASARAJNA on the PARUSHNI (Ravi): SUDAS of the BHARATAS · Vishvamitra then Vasishtha

Later Vedic sacrifices: RAJASUYA consecration · ASHVAMEDHA territorial · VAJAPEYA peers RATNINS ~12 · Sangrihitri treasurer · Bhagadugha collector · taxes BALI, BHAGA (1/6), SHULKA

Later Vedic: varna HARDENS · VIDATHA GONE · women EXCLUDED · Prajapati supreme BACKWARDS-TRAP: women DOWN not up · rigid varna is LATER · rajan neither owned nor taxed

IRON → SURPLUS → STATE → HIERARCHY

jana + pada: identity moves from KINSHIP to GEOGRAPHY = a state

Monarchies: MAGADHA, KOSALA, VATSA, AVANTI · Republics: VAJJI (Vaishali), MALLA, SHAKYA, KOLIYA

Buddha = SHAKYA · Mahavira = VAJJI country · heterodoxy comes from the republican EAST

Sixteen listed in ANGUTTARA NIKAYA (Jain: BHAGAVATI SUTRA) · lists DIFFER

Capitals: Magadha-RAJGIR/PATALIPUTRA · Kosala-SHRAVASTI · Vatsa-KAUSHAMBI · Avanti-UJJAIN

Vajji-VAISHALI · Anga-CHAMPA · Kashi-VARANASI · Gandhara-TAXILA

2nd URBANISATION: middle GANGA plain · IRON · RICE · NBPW · PUNCH-MARKED COINS (karshapana)

1st had NO coins; 2nd has India's FIRST true coinage · script now READABLE (Brahmi, Kharosthi)

sreni = GUILD · setthi = BANKER · gahapati = HOUSEHOLDER-TAXPAYER · nigama = market town

MAGADHA ORDER: HARYANKA → SHISHUNAGA → NANDA → MAURYA

Bimbisara: Anga, marriages, Rajgir, contemporary of Buddha AND Mahavira

Ajatashatru: KILLED FATHER, fort at Pataligrama, FIRST Council at RAJGIR

Udayin: SHIFTED CAPITAL TO PATALIPUTRA · Kalashoka: SECOND Council at VAISHALI

Shishunaga DESTROYED AVANTI · Mahapadma Nanda = UGRASENA · Dhana Nanda = Alexander's contemporary

WHY MAGADHA: iron · rice alluvium · Ganga+Son · ELEPHANTS · able rulers · UNORTHODOX society

PERSIAN = lasting: Darius I satrapy, BEHISTUN, and KHAROSTHI from ARAMAIC

MACEDONIAN = brief: ALEXANDER 326 BCE · PORUS at the HYDASPES (JHELUM) · MUTINY AT THE BEAS · died Babylon 323 BCE · NEVER fought Magadha, and the Nandas fell to CHANDRAGUPTA instead